

ARTWORK INTERPRETATION

It’s Just Business, Darling

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At first glance, the work appears playful: an impeccably dressed cat rests above an open case of money, cigar in mouth, entirely at ease. Beneath the humour, however, lies a portrait of power made charming - and of ruthlessness made socially acceptable.

The cat is an ideal protagonist because it carries a contradiction. It is soft, elegant and domesticated, yet remains a predator. Its composed, almost weary expression suggests that the decisive act has already taken place. It does not need to threaten anyone; control is conveyed through stillness.

THE TENSION WITHIN THE TITLE

It’s just business removes emotion, responsibility and consequence. Darling introduces intimacy, charm and a faintly patronising tenderness. Together, the words sound like cruelty wrapped in impeccable manners - a justification delivered so gracefully that it almost escapes judgement.

SYMBOLIC LANGUAGE

The divided face - one eye illuminated, the other absorbed by shadow - evokes the distance between public image and private intention. The bow tie and club-like interior turn elegance into a costume of legitimacy. The cigar signifies privilege and self-possession, while the smoke behaves like an alibi: visible for a moment, then impossible to hold.

The open case and scattered banknotes imply that a transaction has been completed, although the viewer is never told who paid the real price. Money is not treated as precious; it is handled with the casualness of someone for whom wealth has become ordinary.

> Ultimately, the painting is not simply about wealth. It is about the language, manners and aesthetics used to make power appear civilised. Its strongest quality lies in the unresolved space between satire and unease: the character looks victorious, but not necessarily fulfilled.